

*Free
Guide*

Build **Premium** Sites with **AI**.

An open primer on using AI to build beautiful sites in an afternoon — the order, the tools, the moves. Made for anyone, no code background needed.

– Luke

If Claude is brand new for you, **read this first.**

This guide assumes you've already opened Claude once or twice. If that's still new, two minutes here and you're caught up. Skip ahead if you're already shipping.

What Claude is

Claude is an AI assistant made by Anthropic. You'll use two pieces of it together: **the Claude app** — the chat window where you talk to it, with a live preview that opens any site it builds — and **Claude Code**, the part that actually writes and edits your site's files for you. Don't worry about the two names: Phase 2 installs both, one step at a time.

You start at claude.com/download — free account, Mac or Windows.

What you actually need to know

You don't need to write code, and you won't have to type any technical commands. The one-time setup in Phase 2 is just a few clicks — you download two apps and add a couple of skills. After that, you only need to be able to:

- **Open Claude** and start a new chat.
- **Type a sentence** — *"Build me a landing page for a coffee brand."*
- **Read what comes back** — Claude builds the site and opens the preview right there in the same window. If something's off, you say *"make the headline bigger"* and it updates live.

That's the whole prerequisite.

Talk to Claude like you'd talk to a smart friend who can also build.

One small thing before you start

The folder you downloaded with this PDF includes a small file called `CLAUDE.md`. **It's already filled in** — you don't need to edit anything. Just keep both files in the **same folder**, then open that folder in Claude. You only do this once.

what's a CLAUDE.md?

think of it as a short note you leave for Claude in your project folder — "when you build sites here, lean toward premium: motion-first, clean typography, no template feel." Claude reads it automatically when you open the folder.

What you're holding

Not a swipe file. Not 12 prompts to copy.

It's the actual order I follow when I sit down to build a site. **Same 5 steps every time.** The boring kind of consistency that makes the work look effortless from outside.

Read it once. Save it somewhere you'll actually find it. Open it next time you're staring at a blank screen with no idea what to do.

One afternoon from now, you'll have a real site. Reference folder picked, tools installed, hero visual generated, layout shipped, polished components dropped in. That's it.
No course to finish, no community to join.

Who this is for

You don't need to write code. You need to read English and be willing to type more than 3 words at a time when you talk to an AI.

If you've ever opened a website and thought *"why does this feel expensive and mine doesn't"*, **you're in the right place.**

One thing before we start

I use every tool below. Most weeks. Some are free. Some cost a bit. When there's a way to skip a middleman and pay 2× less for the same thing, I'll tell you which middleman to skip. No affiliate links anywhere in here. Just the stack.

Let's go.

Plan long, execute short.

"Building got cheap and fast. The thinking is where the work moved."

Building a site used to be the hard part. It isn't anymore. The tools got so fast that you can open one, type *"build me a site,"* and watch something appear. That's exactly the trap. The speed makes it tempting to skip the thinking and just start — and that's where most people quietly ruin a project before it begins.

Here's the habit worth stealing: **the real work happens before you touch the tool**. Decide what you're building and why first — who the brand is, what the site needs to make someone do, how it should feel. By the time you start building, the hard choices are already made, so the site almost falls out of you. Long planning, short execution. Always in that order.

Think of a project like a train that's already moving. Once it's rolling one way, backing it up is slow and painful. Every hour you spend up front on the direction saves you ten later — in corrections, second-guessing, and re-explaining what you actually meant. The tool will happily build the wrong thing fast. **Pointing it the right way is on you.**

So before the next prompt: know the destination. The building is the easy part now. The thinking is the edge.

Phase 1 — Reference

"You can't build premium if you start from a blank screen."

What this phase does

Before you open any tool, you need a folder of sites and images that look the way you want yours to look. Not 50 references. **5 to 8 strong ones.**

This is the most-skipped step. Most people open Claude cold and try to "design from scratch." The result is generic. AI-generic. The kind of site that looks like every other landing page from 2024.

The fix is simple: spend 20 minutes collecting reference before you build anything.

*most skip
this step
↑*

Why most people skip it

It feels unproductive. You're not "making" anything. But this 20 minutes is the difference between a site that looks like AI made it and one that looks like **a human with taste did.**

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Pinterest account.
- A folder name. Keep it simple. Example: **coffee-brand**.
- 20 minutes uninterrupted.

The steps

Each site has a **precise role**. Don't browse them randomly — go in this order, with this intent.

1. **Pinterest** — *the wide net*. Search the **vibe**, not "website design". Try "editorial hero typography", "vintage soda packaging", "3D card landing". Pin 6 to 8 images that all share something — color tone, type, energy. If the board looks chaotic, you haven't picked a direction yet. Keep filtering. pinterest.com
2. **Behance** — *the brand system*. Search the same vibe keywords. Save 1-2 design concept projects that show the **full brand**: palette extracted, typography rules, asset system, logo construction. These are your references for everything that lives around the site — cards, packaging, social, identity. behance.net
3. **MotionSites** — *the hero hook*. Save 2-3 sites whose **opening visual or first 5 seconds** would land your audience. This is where you steal the impact: a video hero, a parallax reveal, an entrance animation. motionsites.ai
4. **Dribbble** — *the structure + spare parts*. Save 1-2 shots that show **full layout structures** for the kind of site you're building (long-form scroll, dashboard, product page). Then save 1-2 more for micro-details: a button hover, a footer pattern, a form transition. dribbble.com

End of phase: 5 to 8 reference assets in your folder, each one with a known job — mood, brand system, hero impact, structure, micro-detail.

tip

don't pick references at random. decide in one sentence what you're going for ("a calm coffee shop with a vintage feel") and only save things that match. references that contradict each other confuse Claude later.

Phase 2 — Setup

What this phase does

You install the two tools you'll build with — **the Claude app and Claude Code** — plus a few "skills" that give Claude real design taste before you type a word. This is the part most people get stuck on, so I'll go slow and show every step. *one-time only ↑*

This is a **one-time setup**. After today, you skip straight to Phase 3.

Why this matters

Plain Claude is smart but doesn't have strong opinions about design. The skills below give it opinions. They're free, they install in seconds, and they turn the difference between a website that's *correct* and one that looks **premium**.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A computer (Mac or Windows, both work).
- A free Anthropic account (claude.com).
- 30 minutes one time.

The steps — install Claude

Two downloads, in order — both just a button. Take them one at a time and you can't get lost.

1. **Get the Claude app.** Go to claude.com/download, install it, and sign in with your free account. Mac or Windows, both work. This is your home base — the window where you talk to Claude.
2. **Add Claude Code.** This is the more powerful version, the one that actually builds your site. Go to its page at claude.com/claude-code and [download it the same easy way](#) — one click, exactly like the app.
3. **That's it — it lives inside the app.** Once it's installed, Claude Code sits **right inside the Claude app you just opened**, like a stronger engine on top. Nothing separate to run. Open the app, look top-left, and switch over to *Code* — that's where you'll work from now on.

prefer the terminal? optional.

at the bottom of that same page there's a one-line command you can paste into the terminal instead — same result. if "terminal" means nothing to you, skip it and use the download button. you never need it.

The steps — add skills

Skills are opinions you hand to Claude — real design taste it uses every time it builds. There are two kinds, and you add them two different ways. Once you've seen both, it takes seconds.

Official skills — from inside Claude

These are made by Anthropic and live **right inside the app**. Click the "+" in Claude Code, choose **Add plugin**, and a little directory opens. Find the one you want, click it, and it drops straight into Claude. **No terminal, no command** — one click, done.

Community skills — a link in the chat

The best ones from other makers (like **UI-UX Pro Max**) aren't in that directory — they live on GitHub (a free site where makers share their work). Open the skill's GitHub page, copy the **page link** from your browser's address bar, go back to Claude in the **chat**, paste the link and say "*install this skill*." It reads the page and sets itself up. Same result, still no terminal.

The 4 to start with

- **Frontend Design** — sharpens the actual look: spacing, type, polish. **Start here.** (official → the "+")
- **UI-UX Pro Max** — a real range of layouts and palettes, so your sites stop looking like the same template. (community → link in chat)
- **Superpowers** — a whole disciplined way of working. (community → link in chat)
- **Skill Creator** — for when you want to make your own. (official → the "+")

tip

don't grab 30 skills on day one — that's how you drown. start with these few, build a couple of sites, then add more only when a real project actually asks for it.

Phase 3 — Visuals + Motion

"The hero image is half the site. Generate it yourself, in your style, for free."

What this phase does

You make the **hero image** (the big visual at the top) yourself, with AI. Then you turn that image into a **5-second loop** so the page actually moves when someone lands on it.

Most workflow guides push you straight to Higgsfield or Runway here.

\$30 a month, "all in one." I'm telling you to skip them.

Why those tools are overpriced

They're wrappers. The image generator inside Higgsfield is the same Nano Banana 2 you can hit for free at Google AI Studio. The video generator is one of three open models they license, with a markup on top.

You pay for the dashboard. Not for the output.

If you can click between two browser tabs without crying, you save **\$20 to \$40 a month** and get exactly the same files at the source. Sometimes higher resolution, since the source doesn't compress them as aggressively.

*save \$40/mo
← right here*

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Google account (aistudio.google.com sign-in).
- A Kling AI account (klingai.com) with a starter credit pack (\$5-10 covers a lot).

The steps

1. **Open Google AI Studio** at aistudio.google.com. Sign in. In the model dropdown, pick Nano Banana 2 (Google's latest image model). On the **right-side panel**, set the **aspect ratio** you need (16:9 for hero, 1:1 for square, 9:16 for vertical) and bump **resolution to 4K**. Free tier covers plenty.
2. **Let Claude write the prompt for you**. Don't try to write the perfect visual prompt yourself — Claude is better at it. Open Claude, describe what you want in one casual sentence, and ask it to turn that into a full prompt.

you → claude

Write me a Nano Banana 2 prompt to generate a hero image for a website. I'll give you the brief in one line. Output a structured prompt with subject, lighting, mood, composition, aspect ratio 16:9, cinematic feel.

a perfume bottle floating mid-air with a soft blurred background

Claude returns a full structured prompt. **Copy. Paste into Google AI Studio**. Generate 3-4 variations. Pick your favorite. Download highest resolution.

3. **Animate the image**. Same trick — Claude writes the motion prompt for you. Open Kling AI at klimgai.com and upload your image. Two paths depending on what you want:

For a subtle loop (background motion, atmospheric feel) — ask Claude:

you → claude

Write me a Kling Image-to-Video prompt for this hero. I want a slow camera push-in, 5 seconds, looped. ONE motion only.

Paste into Kling. Multiple motions in a single prompt confuse the model. Make it loop. Generate. Download MP4.

For something more articulate (a scene morph, a transformation between two distinct frames) — generate a second image as your end frame, then use Kling's "*Image-to-Video with End Frame*" to interpolate between the two. Claude stitches the resulting clips together inside your project — no external editor needed.

4. **Convert MP4 to GIF** or to a looped video file using ezgif.com (free). Compress to under 2MB so it loads fast on mobile.
5. **Save the file** in your project folder as `hero-video.mp4` or `hero.gif`. Phase 4 tells Claude to embed it.

Phase 4 — Build

"Three rounds. Structure first. Motion second. Polish last. Don't try to nail it in one shot."

What this phase does

You open Claude and have an actual conversation that produces a working website. Not one giant prompt that does everything. **Three focused rounds**, each fixing what the previous one didn't get right.

*3 rounds,
not 1 ↑*

Why most people get bad results

They try to write one huge prompt that says *"build me a beautiful hero with motion and a contact form and a footer and make it premium."* Claude tries to do everything at once and does each part badly.

Three smaller rounds gives Claude a chance to get the bones right before you ask for fancy details.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- Your reference folder from Phase 1.
- Your hero video file from Phase 3.
- 90 to 120 minutes of focused time.

The steps (3 rounds)

Three rounds — but the order is **more flexible than it looks**. Sometimes the visual you made in Phase 3 is strong enough that the whole site should be built *around it* — letting it shape the tone, the typography, even the section choices. When that's the case, share the image with Claude before you do anything else.

- 1. Round 1 — structure.** Open Claude, start a new project, and ask it to build the page structure: which sections, in what order, with what kind of typography.
No animations yet, no fancy details. If your hero visual is the centerpiece of the brand, share it now and tell Claude to design the layout to match its tone. Otherwise, ask it to leave a placeholder where the hero video will go in round 2. Claude opens the preview in the same window — check the layout makes sense.
- 2. Round 2 — motion.** Tell Claude to embed the video file you made in Phase 3 as a full-screen looping background in the hero. Then ask for subtle fade-ins on the text as the user scrolls, and to keep the motion smooth and light. The preview refreshes. Scroll through. The site should now feel alive.
- 3. Round 3 — polish.** Two parts here. First: open your reference folder from Phase 1 and pick 2-3 micro-details you want to steal (a button hover glow, tighter letter spacing on headlines, a faded line between sections). Send them all in one message. Then: **fine-tune the motion**. If the hero feels too fast, the scroll too jerky, or a transition is off, just say so — Claude will slow it down, smooth the easing, soften the timing.

When Claude gets it wrong

It will. Round 1 or round 2, something won't work. Normal. The fix is one sentence: describe what's broken, then describe what you want instead. Example: *"the hero text is hard to read against the video, add a 30% dark overlay between them so the headline pops."* Done in seconds.

Don't start over. Don't restart the project. Just keep talking.

tip

if round 3 breaks something that worked in round 2, ask: "show me what changed in the last edit." Claude lists the diff. then revert just the broken bit instead of nuking everything.

Phase 5 — Components

"Don't reinvent the form, the marquee, or the footer. Import them. Polish them. Move on."

What this phase does

Some pieces of every website are [solved problems](#). A nice contact form. A scrolling logo marquee. A pricing table that doesn't look like a spreadsheet. You don't need Claude to build these from scratch. You import them from a registry, paste them into your project, and ask Claude to restyle them to match your site.

This is the step that makes a *"good"* site look like a *"premium"* site without adding hours of work.

Why this saves your sanity

Form validation, accessibility, mobile keyboard handling, edge cases.

These take days to get right from scratch. The components below have been polished by hundreds of designers already. Use them.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- Your site from Phase 4 working on your computer.
- 30 minutes.

The steps

Components aren't templates to paste in unchanged — think of them as **references**. You can grab the bits you love (a button glow, a header animation, a footer pattern) and **remix them**. Claude is happy to take an effect from one component and apply it somewhere else.

1. **Open 21st.dev** at 21st.dev. Browse the registry — it's a library of ready-made pieces: contact forms, scrolling logo strips, footers, pricing tables, animated buttons, hover effects. Look for the ones *you like the feel of*.
2. **Copy the component prompt** for each one you want. Every piece on 21st.dev has a copy button that grabs a block of text describing it in full — ready to hand to Claude.
3. **Paste it into Claude with a natural sentence** — like: *"Let's use this card for the 'How we work' section."* Or: *"Drop this footer at the bottom and restyle it to match the rest of the site."* No special syntax. Claude reads the prompt and places the piece where you said.
4. **The preview refreshes**. The new pieces should now look like they were always part of your site.
5. **Remix freely**. If you saw a button glow you loved on one component, just tell Claude: *"take that glow effect and apply it to the main button on the hero too."* You're feeding Claude inspiration, not locking yourself into one template.

Phase 6 — Deploy

"Your site is done. One conversation and it's online, at a real URL, for free."

What this phase does

Up to now your site has only existed **on your own computer**. To share it — with a client, a friend, the world — it needs to live on the public internet. The good news: there's a free service made exactly for this, and **Claude handles most of the wiring**. You don't need to learn what a server is, or how to upload anything. You just sign up to one site and click "yes" a couple of times.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED BEFORE STARTING

- A free Vercel account (vercel.com).
- The site you built in Phase 4 working on your computer.
- 5 minutes.

The steps

1. **Sign up at vercel.com** — free, no card needed.
2. **Back in Claude, ask:** *"deploy this site to Vercel for me."* Claude handles all the technical setup — you just click "yes" on Vercel a couple of times when it asks for permission.
3. **A live URL appears** — something like `your-site.vercel.app`. Open it. Share it. **It's online.**

tip

every time you tweak something later, just say "redeploy" in Claude and Vercel updates the live site automatically. no manual uploads, ever.

How to spot a premium site.

"It's rarely about budget. It's a handful of things your eye already notices but can't name yet."

Some sites read as expensive and others read as cheap. Name the reasons, and you can't unsee them — on every site you visit, and on your own.

Space. Empty room isn't wasted room. It's what makes a page feel calm and intentional. Cram everything together and it reads cheap before a single word does.

One accent. Premium palettes stay tight: a couple of neutrals and one accent color, used rarely. The accent has power *because* it's rare.

Type. A font reads cheap or expensive faster than almost anything else. The quiet trick: one font family, a few weights — bold for headings, regular for body, light for the calm parts.

One loud thing. A premium page decides what you see first, second, third. There's always one clear focal point, and everything else waits its turn.

One ask. Give a visitor five equally loud buttons and they click none. One obvious next move beats a wall of options every time.

the 50ms rule

people decide whether they trust a page in about 50 milliseconds — faster than they can read a word. that snap judgment is almost all how it looks, not what it says.

That's the workflow.

One file came with this PDF in the bundle you downloaded:

1. A `CLAUDE.md` config file you can drop into the root of any Claude project. It biases Claude toward premium output: motion-first, video heroes, clean typography, no template feel.

A TIP WORTH GOLD ★

Don't just read this — hand it to Claude. Drop this guide and the `CLAUDE.md` that came with it into a Claude project, and it takes in the whole workflow at once: the standards, the order, the way premium gets built. From there, every site you make with it starts from here instead of generic defaults. You bring the taste, Claude brings the memory.

I hope this helps you turn the ideas you've been carrying around
into something real.

Let me know what you think — this guide stays free, and keeps getting sharper.

— Luke

P.S. There's a deeper version of this. This free guide is the workflow — the moves, the order, the stack. The **Masterclass** goes into the part that's harder to fit on a page: art direction and taste, building a real identity, type and color that carry the price tag, 3D and motion, the intelligence layer behind the work, and how to actually charge for it. It's the difference between a site that's *correct* and one that feels expensive on purpose. It's out now at lukewebdesign.com — \$29, and every update stays yours as it grows.

Plain-English glossary

If a term in this guide tripped you up, look here.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS IN PLAIN ENGLISH
Hero section	The big visual area at the top of a website. The first thing visitors see.
Reference (folder)	The collection of sites and images you save before designing, so your site has a clear taste direction instead of looking AI-generic.
Prompt	The exact words you type to Claude (or any AI) to ask it to do something.
Skill	A small add-on you install in Claude that gives it specific knowledge or opinions.
Library / dependency	Pre-written code other people made that you can include in your project. Motion is a library for animations.
Component	A pre-built piece of a website (like a form or a footer) that you import instead of building from scratch.
Registry	A website like 21st.dev where you browse and copy components.
Easing	The speed curve of an animation — how it accelerates and slows down. "Smoother easing" means a gentler, less abrupt motion.
Localhost	Your website running on your own computer, only visible to you, before you put it online.
Deploy	The act of putting your finished website online so others can visit it.
Mobile-friendly	Looks good on phones, tablets, and computers without breaking.

Build something **premium** this week.

This is a curated primer — I keep refining it as the workflow gets sharper.

Every update is free, and lands in your inbox automatically.

The **Masterclass** goes deeper into all of it — *art direction, identity, type, color, 3D, motion, strategy*, and working with real clients.

Built so anyone can follow it.

Out now at lukewebdesign.com — \$29, lifetime updates included.

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